Leonhard Gebhardt

Assistant Professor of Strategy and Entrepreneurship
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PROFILE

With a background in art history, economics, and nonprofit management, I work with entrepreneurs, in places, and on the ecosystems that unfold between them. I see entrepreneurial ecosystems as relational spaces and employ design science research to produce, together with practitioners, rigorous knowledge that can be put to use. Before joining academia, I was active in social entrepreneurship, cultural organizations, and public startup funding, and founded a venture that reissued a Bauhaus toy.

Research interests: entrepreneurial ecosystems, resonance and relational perspectives on entrepreneurship, sustainable entrepreneurship, design science research

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Since Jan 2023 — **ICN Business School**, CEREFIGE, University of Lorraine, Nancy, France
Strategy and Entrepreneurship Department
Assistant Professor

Jan–Dec 2022 — **Project Management Jülich (PtJ)**, Forschungszentrum Jülich, Berlin, Germany
Scientific Advisor in the EXIST program of the Federal Ministry for Economic Affairs and Climate Action (BMWK)
- Selecting and advising early-stage startup teams for spin-off grants
- Building regional ecosystems for AI startups in Germany

Oct 2016–Dec 2021 — **HTW Berlin – University of Applied Sciences**, Germany
Digital Value Hub: Digital Transformation for Berlin SMEs
Research Associate in projects funded by the ERDF and the Berlin Senate
- Digital maturity analysis of 63 companies in workshops
- Prototyping of digitalization projects
- Dissemination through articles, books, and events

2015–2016 — **Bauspiel.org**
Co-Founder
Documentation and re-issue of a toy designed by Bauhaus artist Alma Siedhoff-Buscher, held in the collection of the Bauhaus-Archiv Berlin

2009–2014 — **Earlier positions** in social entrepreneurship, culture, and consulting
Berghof Foundation, Berlin – Assistant Finance and Administration, internship (Apr–Sep 2014)
Ashoka Mexico y Centroamérica, Mexico City – Intern, Venture & Fellowship (Sep–Nov 2013)
Deutsche Kindermedienstiftung Goldener Spatz, Erfurt – Assistant Organization (Mar–Jun 2013)
Goldene Zwanziger, Jena – Student consultant, marketing and advertising (Jun 2011–Apr 2012)
Maon Levzeller, Herzliya, Israel – Civil service abroad in a home for people with disabilities (Sep 2009–Aug 2010)

EDUCATION

2018–2024 — **University of Stuttgart**, Faculty of Management, Economics and Social Sciences
Doctoral degree, *magna cum laude* (defense March 2024)
Dissertation: A Multilevel Study of Sustainable Entrepreneurship
Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Katharina Hölzle, Prof. Dr. Alexander Brem
Doctoral studies began at the University of Potsdam, Faculty of Economics and Social Sciences (Jan 2018–Mar 2023)

Oct 2014–Sep 2016	**HTW Berlin & HWR Berlin**, Germany MA Nonprofit Management and Public Governance
Oct 2010–Sep 2014	**Friedrich Schiller University Jena**, Germany BA Art History and Film Studies, Economics
Sep–Dec 2012	**Universidad Rey Juan Carlos**, Madrid, Spain Exchange student, Business Administration and Management

PUBLICATIONS

Journal articles and conference proceedings

Gebhardt, L., Kaus, J., & Hölzle, K. (2026). Strategic agencement: How sustainable entrepreneurs address the dual liabilities of newness and otherness. *Entrepreneurship & Regional Development*, 38(3–4), 263–286.

Gebhardt, L., & Remke, K. (2025). Sustainability in supermodernity: Design principles for innovating non-places. In *International Conference on Design Science Research in Information Systems and Technology (DESRIST)* (pp. 115–129). Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland.

Adusei, E., Halaszovich, T., & **Gebhardt, L.** (2025). Greening the nexus between managerial innovativeness and innovation performance of manufacturing SMEs: The mediating role of green ambidexterity. *Business Strategy and the Environment*, 34(6), 7016–7032.

Jimenez, J. C., Norris, S., & **Gebhardt, L.** (2024). For the good of the people: Establishing public value creation as an objective for sustainable entrepreneurship policy. *International Journal of Entrepreneurial Venturing*, 16(2), 242–261.

Gebhardt, L., & Bachmann, N. (2023). Entrepreneurial contributions to sustainability transitions—A longitudinal study of their representation and enactment through topic modeling and thematic analysis. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 420, 138255.

Gebhardt, L., & Hölzle, K. (2023). Scaling sustainable entrepreneurship for impact: Design knowledge for the use of digital technologies. In *International Conference on Design Science Research in Information Systems and Technology (DESRIST)* (pp. 177–190). Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland.

Books and book chapters

Bodung, T., Erdle, K., **Gebhardt, L.**, & Waubke, R. (Eds.) (2021). *Digital Value*. Berlin: Berliner Wissenschafts-Verlag.

Hartmann, M., Waubke, R., & **Gebhardt, L.** (2021). Productivity paradox in digital innovation for SMEs. In *Digitalization* (pp. 145–152). Cham: Springer.

Hartmann, M., **Gebhardt, L.**, & Waubke, R. (2020). Empirische Erfahrungen zum Digital Entrepreneurship in KMU [Empirical insights on digital entrepreneurship in SMEs]. In *Perspektiven des Entrepreneurships: Unternehmerische Konzepte zwischen Theorie und Praxis* (pp. 313–330). Stuttgart: Schäffer-Poeschel.

Hartmann, M., & **Gebhardt, L.** (2019). Die neue Nachhaltigkeit im Unternehmertum [The new sustainability in entrepreneurship]. In *Neue Betriebswirtschaft: Theorien, Methoden, Geschäftsfelder* (pp. 593–617). Tübingen: UVK.

Work under review

Gebhardt, L., & Opdenakker, R. Sustainability drivers in entrepreneurial ecosystems: A systematic literature review and synthesis of design propositions. Second-round revise and resubmit, *Technovation*.

Gebhardt, L. From ecosystem conduciveness to resonance: Reframing entrepreneurial ecosystems as relational spaces of organizational genesis. Under review, *Organization Theory*.

Bade, M., Müller, C. E., & **Gebhardt, L.** Internalizing ecosystem functions: Evidence from academic entrepreneurship policy. Under review, *Research Policy*.

Gebhardt, L., Bade, M., & Norris, S. Preserving social value orientation after seed funding: The role of place-based factors. Submitted to *Entrepreneurship & Regional Development*.

Müller, C. E., Kellberger, S., & **Gebhardt, L.** Empowering early-stage female entrepreneurs: Evaluation insights from Germany's EXIST-Women pilot. Second-round revise and resubmit, *International Journal of Gender and Entrepreneurship*.

Müller, C. E., Bade, M., & **Gebhardt, L.** Beyond plan or no plan: Advancing the stage of business planning in entrepreneurship research. Under review, *Revue de l'Entrepreneuriat*.

RESEARCH PROJECTS, GRANTS AND AWARDS

Since 2025	**Einstein Center for Early Disease Interception (EC-EDI)**, Berlin Principal Investigator, education and entrepreneurship training. Consortium of twelve Berlin institutions (total funding €6 million) developing and implementing new approaches to disease prevention
2024	**ICN Business School** – Research seed funding
2022, 2019	**Potsdam Graduate School (PoGS)** – Travel stipend (€1,800)
2021	**Research Commission for Young Scientists (FNK), HTW Berlin** – Research grant (€4,674)
2017	**Best Paper Award**, 18th Young Scientists Conference, Mittweida (Master's thesis)

EDITORIAL AND REVIEWING ACTIVITIES

Ongoing	**Guest Editor** (with co-editors), Special Issue in *International Journal of Technology Management*, following the ARTEM OCC conference
Ad-hoc reviewer	*Business Strategy and the Environment, Technological Forecasting and Social Change, Business and Society Review*

CONFERENCE ORGANIZATION AND PRESENTATIONS

Organization

2025	Co-organizer, **ARTEM OCC** – Organizational Creativity and Sustainability Conference, "Paths on Creativity, Innovation, and Sustainability in the Age of Disruption," Berlin, Germany
2024	Co-organizer, Professional Development Workshop "Pursuing Impact in Entrepreneurship Research with Design Science Approaches," **RENT** – Research in Entrepreneurship and Small Business Conference, Nantes, France

Selected presentations

2025	"Sustainability in Supermodernity." **Academy of Management Annual Meeting**, Copenhagen, Denmark
2024	"Preservation of Social Value Orientation in Seed-Funded Startups," **RENT** 2024, Nantes, France
2024	"Reframing Entrepreneurial Ecosystems with Resonance: Cinematic Arguments," **40th EGOS Colloquium**, Milan, Italy
2023	"Scaling Sustainable Entrepreneurship for Impact: Design Knowledge for the Use of Digital Technologies," **18th DESRIST** – International Conference on Design Science Research in Information Systems and Technology, Pretoria, South Africa
2023	"Bringing Sustainability Back into Entrepreneurial Ecosystems: A Review and Research Agenda," **23rd EURAM** – European Academy of Management Conference, Dublin, Ireland
2022	"Trading Sovereignty for Business Model's Potential in Digital Business Ecosystems – A Faustian Bargain for Sustainable Entrepreneurs?," **Academy of Management Annual Meeting**, Seattle, USA
2022	"Think Globally, Embed Locally—How Sustainable Entrepreneurs Use Entrepreneurial Ecosystem Embeddedness (3e) for Resourcing and Impact," **Granada International Doctoral Summer School in Entrepreneurship Research**, University of Granada, Spain
2021	"Closing the Digital Divide: A Digital Intrapreneurship Framework Building on Design Science Research," **RENT** 2021, Turku, Finland

Invited talks

Jan 2025	"The Startup Ecosystem for Social and Sustainable Entrepreneurship", Willy Brandt School of Public Policy, University of Erfurt (associated with Social Entrepreneurship course, led by Prof. Dr. Heike Grimm)
Apr 2023	„Startup-Ökosysteme im ländlichen Raum" [Startup ecosystems in rural areas], opening of AngerWERK – center for public-interest startups, socio-ecological transformation and regional engagement, Angermünde, Brandenburg
Jun 2018	„Auf dem Weg zur Digitalisierung von Kleinen und Mittleren Unternehmen in Berlin" [Toward the digitalization of SMEs in Berlin], workshop "Berufsschule digital," Deutsche Kinder- und Jugendstiftung (DKJS), ExRotaprint, Berlin
Feb 2018	„Digitalisierung in Berliner Unternehmen" [Digitalization in Berlin companies], with Prof. Dr. Matthias Hartmann, Unternehmens-Netzwerk Motzener Straße, Berlin

TEACHING

ICN Business School, Berlin and Paris campuses (selection)

2026	Sustainable Management and Organizations (Master in Management (MiM), Berlin)
2025	Executive MBA study visit – organization and guest lecture (Berlin)
2024, 2025	Innovation, Agility and Design Thinking (MSc, Paris)
2023, 2024, 2025	Strategy (MiM, Berlin)
2023	Corporate Strategy and Innovation (MSc, Paris)
2023, 2024, 2025	Business Functions – enterprise simulation [CESIM] (MSc, Paris)
2023, 2024	Strategic Challenge – student consulting project (MiM, Berlin and Paris)
2023, 2026	Research Methods and Data Science (MSc, Paris)
2022, 2023	Governance, Responsible Leadership, Risk Management (MiM, Berlin)

HTW Berlin and HWR Berlin

2018–2022	General Management – enterprise simulation [TOPSIM], HTW Berlin
2018–2020	Digital Business Seminar, HTW Berlin
2017–2018	Project Study on Public Marketing (Master), HWR Berlin

SUPERVISION AND MENTORING

Since 2025	Co-supervisor of the doctoral thesis of Priscilla Boatemaa Appiah, Willy Brandt School of Public Policy, University of Erfurt
Since 2024	Co-supervisor of the doctoral thesis of Enoch Adusei, ICN Business School
Apr 2025	Member of the dissertation committee of B. Jamitzky, Constructor University Bremen

TRAINING AND SKILLS

Oct–Dec 2025	Natural Language Processing with Deep Learning, Stanford Online
Sep 2019–Nov 2020	Berliner Zertifikat für Hochschullehre [Berlin Certificate for Higher Education Teaching], 204 units of 45 min, Berliner Zentrum für Hochschullehre (joint institution of the 13 public universities in Berlin and Charité – Universitätsmedizin Berlin)
Feb 2020	Body Language and Rhetoric seminar, Institut für Managementberatung
Languages	German (native) · English (fluent) · Spanish (good) · French (basic) · Modern Hebrew (basic)
Software	MAXQDA, Stata, SPSS, R · Python · LaTeX, MS Office